My daughter Emma writes songs and gets inspiration from many places

Today's sermon comes from a song Emma just released called Invitation

- The song acts as a prayer & invitation for all to come to Jesus
    - Whoever has ears come hear the good news
    - Whoever has eyes come see what he can do
    - The lyrics she writes come with amazing daddy/daughter theological convos
    - We read through Matt 13 during her recording process
    - The song Invitation is available on al platforms
- Matthew 's gospel chapter 13 has many parables
- A parable is a story from everyday life used as an illustration
    - Jesus taught 7 parables in Matt 13 about the Kingdom of God
        - Each story was relatable but ambigious to make people think
    - The audience that day & the audience Matthew most had in mind were Jewish

Matthew 13:1-10

That same day Jesus went out of the house and sat beside the sea. 2 And great crowds gathered about him, so that he got into a boat and sat down. And the whole crowd stood on the beach. 3 And he told them many things in parables, saying: "A sower went out to sow. 4 And as he sowed, some seeds fell along the path, and the birds came and devoured them. 5 Other seeds fell on rocky ground, where they did not have much soil, and immediately they sprang up, since they had no depth of soil, 6 but when the sun rose they were scorched. And since they had no root, they withered away. 7 Other seeds fell among thorns, and the thorns grew up and choked them. 8 Other seeds fell on good soil and produced grain, some a hundredfold, some sixty, some thirty. 9 He who has ears,[a] let him hear."

An honest question comes from Jesus disciples

Matt 13:10 Why do you speak to them in parables?

Jesus answered the disciples like this:

Matt 13:11-17

11 And he answered them, “To you it has been given to know the secrets of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it has not been given.

- Here we see a distinction Jesus makes between the disciples and the crowd

12-13 For to the one who has, more will be given, and he will have an abundance, but from the one who has not, even what he has will be taken away. **13** This is why I speak to them in parables, because seeing they do not see, and hearing they do not hear, nor do they understand.

- For the one who has(secrets to the kingdom)
  - surrendered heart posture (open ears & eyes)
  - Hearing a parable they will see more of the kingdom
- The one who has not (secrets to the kingdom)
  - Rejected heart posture (closed ears & eye)
  - They will become frustrated
- Jesus was not teasing or punishing he was revealing heart conditions

14-15 Indeed, in their case the prophecy of Isaiah is fulfilled that says:

“You will indeed hear but never understand,and you will indeed see but never perceive.” **15** For this people's heart has grown dull,
and with their ears they can barely hear,and their eyes they have closed,lest they should see with their eyes and hear with their ears
and understand with their heart and turn, and I would heal them.’

- Jesus references the OT prophet Isaiah

- Isaiah experiences a powerful vision where God commands that he warn Israel about their coming judgement
- Israel was so far gone that they will not even hear the message
- God still speaks through the prophet
- Look at the promise at the end see/hear/understand with their heart = God will heal
- Heal who? –the rebellious—the sinful—the undeserving

Whoever has ears come hear the good news whoever has eyes come see what he can do!

16-17 But blessed are your eyes, for they see, and your ears, for they hear.
17 For truly, I say to you, many prophets and righteous people longed to see what you see, and did not see it, and to hear what you hear, and did not hear it.

See/Hear/Understand with the heart—Turn—Then healed

But the heart is not how we describe it

- we say my heart feels alive when.. or my heart hurts when…
- we talk about the heart's reaction
- In both the OT and NT the heart means
  - The center of who we are
  - Our real desire—not superficial
  - The true mind & will
  - The invitation says He just wants your heart
  - Jesus doesn't want an emotion --- he wants real desire
  - Jesus doesn't want a feeling – he wants all of them

The good news is really good to those who can

hear/see & understand it

What kept Israel from hearing & seeing in Isaiah 6?

What kept the people in Matthew 13 from hearing and seeing?

Warning: to those who do not grasp the gospel the enemy comes to take it away.

- Jesus' response shows it was selective.
- For the people in Matt 13 there were 2 challenges to the seed taking root

1. **Difficulties**
   - Rocky soil—no roots or growth
   - Trouble comes & they quit on God
2. **Distractions**.
   - Thorny soil—worries if life
   - Wrong desires--choke out

God still reaches out to both & they leave him unread

What keeps me or us from hearing and seeing today?

- Jesus speaks through his word –-what do we do?
- Jesus speaks through his spirit—what do we do?
- Jesus still speaks through prophets and gifts—what do we do?

The condition of our spiritual ears & eyes is important –

Ear muffs and glasses

- **Sometimes**
  - I want to keep the rocks & thorns in my soil
  - I filter the understanding of the bible with my pain
  - I filter the understanding of the bible with my worry & fear
  - I hear & see through my politics & current events more than anything
    - The more I choose to limit what I hear and see I slowly block out what God wants to say

We all come from a posture & position that needs to be surrendered to Jesus

The case study

- A professor of New Testament studies named Mark Allan Powell tested his students in literary criticism to show how people have different perspectives reading scripture.
- He challenged them to read the story of the prodigal son and retell it from memory
- Let's read the parable and then I'll explain the results of the study

Luke 15:11-18 And he said, "There was a man who had two sons. 12 And the younger of them said to his father, 'Father, give me the share of property that is coming to me.' And he divided his property between them. 13 Not many days later, the younger son gathered all he had and took a journey into a far country, and there he squandered his property in reckless living. 14 And when he had spent everything, a severe famine arose in that country, and he began to be in need. 15 So he went and hired himself out to[b] one of the citizens of that country, who sent him into his fields to feed pigs. 16 And he was longing to be fed with the pods that the pigs ate, and no one gave him anything.17 "But when he came to himself, he said, 'How many of my father's hired servants have more than enough bread, but I perish here with hunger! 18 I will arise and go to my father, and I will say to him, "Father, I have sinned against heaven and before you.

- The study was first conducted with 12 students
- Then 100 American students diverse in age, gender, race & background.
    - 100 % mentioned the squandering of the money
    - only 6% mentioned the famine.
- The American students focused heavily on the son's personal spending habits being familiar with the same

- The study was then repeated with students from Russia and the results changed.

    - 34% of students mentioned the squandering of the money
    - 84% mentioned the famine
- Russian students whose cultural memory is shaped by historical family displacement and severe wartime famines, viewed the famine as the catastrophic turning point.

The prodigal son—his squandered money and the famine were conditions of his life but it was the condition of his heart that caused him to go to his father

Is there anything that keeps you from hearing, seeing & understanding Jesus?

The apostle Paul

- murderer at one point
- wrote to a church in Rome who was under Roman oppression

Romans 10:13 For “everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.”

You can’t do this on your own but the invitation is here
An invitation for forgiveness—salvation

Whoever has ears come hear the good news
Whoever has eyes come see what he can do
I can’t compare this man to anyone
He gave up his life so we’d become one

- Whoever means whoever.
- When you’re invited to a party you just come
- The details of the experience await your rsvp.
    - You don’t become a chef to fully comprehend the meal
    - You don’t first become a baker to decorate the cake
    - You just. Come as you are—because you were invited

Is there anyone today who would accept the invitation to know Jesus without limits?